

ROUGH CUT **KAVEREE BAMZAI**

The Boys Have It



Yes, it's very exciting that IPL games are doing so well on television, but please has anyone stopped to think what the alternative was? Soaps with bathos sown in their sari pallus and a game show with a charming host but questions that remind every 10-year-old of what they don't know—I don't know about you, but the 10-year-olds I know bear no resemblance to the super smart actors pretending to be ordinary students on the sets of *Kya Aap Paanchvi Paas Se Tez Hain?* Why would any family, and please remember 97 per cent of India still has one television set, not watch the concoction of glamour and gall that unfolds onscreen every evening? The popcorn is almost free, there's usually a celebrity controversy to catch on news channels during the advertisement breaks, and hey, even the ads are not too bad.

The ratings of all shows, even the top rated soaps, has been in a freefall. In their place, the season's biggest reality show ushers in a new scorcher every day, typically titled by hungry news channels in their unique language: *Veer vs Zaara* or *Yuvi vs Mahi*. Which would explain why 15-24-year-old men have shown the highest TRP gains, clearly the walk-ins from English entertainment channels and Hindi news networks. All channel heads have been wrongfooted because no one expected the cricket fever to last. Even the third week of the matches have delivered an average of 4.5 TRP. Though lower than the last two weeks' average of 5.5 and 5 TRPs, it's still much higher than anything else—the top 10 shows were all related to IPL, and the Star Plus saga, *Bidaayi*, came in only at number 11.



But fast food cricket hasn't won over women, though that is the popular perception. The viewership is 36 per cent women, down from 41 per cent during the 2003 cricket World Cup. These women are clearly bored by whatever they are watching on TV—yes, even Shane Warne and M.S. Dhoni. The total television viewing universe has not grown, though pink papers faithfully report the growth of sales of TV sets during every major tournament. Will the two new general entertainment channels, TV18 and Viacom's oddly-named Colors and the Alva Brothers joint venture with Turner do anything different for them? Not very likely. Everyone's thinking in circles, trying to recreate lost magic. And from what one can see coming up—sleepy Salman Khan anchoring *Dus ka Dam* and the next edition of a reality show with Javed Akhtar and/or Urmila Matondkar as judge—nothing is going to rescue the viewer. No matter how many TV sets she buys.

RUBEN SINGH



SOFT TARGET: An ARC aircraft at IGIA

In Plane Sight

DELHI The Research and Analysis Wing's (RAW) cloak-and-dagger air wing, the Aviation Research Centre (ARC), is something few people know about. For good reason. Its aircraft—a mix of IL-76 heavy lift aircraft, Boeing 707s, IAI Astras, Gulfstreams and Learjets and helicopters like the Mi-8—fly spy missions and are used for covertly transporting 'cargo' ranging from captured terrorists to nuclear weapons. They are the wings, eyes and ears of Indian intelligence patterned on the CIA's Air America (incidentally, it was established with help from the American agency after the 1962 Indo-China war).

The ARC operates out of airfields like Dum Duma in Assam, Charbatia in Orissa and Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGIA). The location and disposition of this motley fleet has always been a mystery. But not any longer, after the recent opening of the new Gurgaon flyover. The flyover whizzes you to Delhi's

south-western suburb, giving motorists a ringside peek of the ARC fleet parked in one corner of the IGIA.

While one could argue that the location of spy aircraft are not secret in the era of real-time satellite imagery—only the capabilities of the surveillance radars and sensors used for cross-border spy missions are—former ARC officials insist there is indeed a direct physical security threat to the fleet. The cluster of closely parked aircraft are located within a kilometre of the low perimeter wall of the airport, well within what is called 'rocket range' in security parlance.

With the flyover now opening up the sensitive fleet to the outside world, rocket propelled grenades or mortars launched from fast-moving vehicles could cripple the eyes and ears of Indian intelligence. Clearly, these are new threats to the secret fleet our forces need waking up to.

by Sandeep Unnithan